

“ I HOPE WE MAY ALL SAY THAT **THUS**, THIS FATEFUL MORNING, **CAME TO AN END ALL WARS.** ”

David Lloyd George, British Prime Minister, November 11, 1918



British soldiers, an American sailor, and a Red Cross nurse celebrate the signing of the armistice on November 11, ending four years of mass slaughter.

their German enemies—a German reference to the Marines as “Devil Dogs” stuck as a nickname for the Corps.

The **turning point** was an **attack at Amiens** on August 8, spearheaded by Australian and Canadian infantry, and supported by massed British and French tanks. Described by the German general Erich Ludendorff (1865–1937) as “the black day of the German army,” it initiated the “Hundred Days” of relentless Allied offensives, with large-scale use of tanks and aircraft.

In September, Pershing achieved his ambition of commanding an independent US operation—the capture of the **St. Mihiel salient**. This was followed by a combined American and French offensive in the **Argonne forest**, the costliest single battle in American history, with 117,000 US casualties.

On September 29, with their Hindenburg Line defenses breached and their ally Bulgaria on the point of surrender, the **Germans sought an armistice**.

They approached President Wilson (1856–1924), hoping to make a deal with the US, but Wilson aligned himself with the British and French, who insisted that Germany should surrender. Although German troops were still putting up a stubborn defense, and there were not yet any Allied troops on German soil, the country was disintegrating from within. A mutiny in the German navy at the end of October was followed by strikes and socialist uprisings in major cities, where food shortages had fueled political discontent.

Germany’s main allies, Turkey and Austria–Hungary, stopped fighting. On November 9, the Social Democrat Philipp Scheidemann declared Germany a republic, and Kaiser Wilhelm II (1859–1941) fled to the Netherlands. Two days later, a German delegation **signed an armistice** in a railroad car in the Compiègne forest. The guns fell silent at 11 a.m. on November 11.

50 MILLION PEOPLE DIED IN THE FLU PANDEMIC OF 1918–19

Peace celebrations erupted in London, Paris, and other Allied cities, but even in the victor nations the reaction was muted by the memory of the millions who had died. There were no celebrations in the collapsed empires destroyed by the conflict—Germany, Austria, Russia, and Turkey—which faced an uncertain future amid political turmoil.

Meanwhile, a global pandemic of “**Spanish Flu**” was at its peak. One of the worst natural disasters in human history, the spread of the disease was probably aided by large-scale movements of troops and by the weakened immune systems of populations suffering from malnutrition. The disease killed more than 50 million people.

Signing the armistice

The Allied delegation, led by Marshal Foch, photographed outside the railroad carriage at Compiègne where the armistice was signed.

